

CHAPTER 10 — Still Awake

“By Friday morning, I hadn’t slept properly for three nights,” Zoe said. “The first night was me. After that, they made sure.”

Elias’s hands tightened slightly on the wheel, then relaxed.

He let the silence remain until Zoe chose to fill it.

“Not couldn’t,” she said. “Wasn’t allowed.”

The first night, fear kept her awake.

Every sound beyond the locked door became footsteps approaching. Every movement of the pipes became someone touching the handle. When she closed her eyes, she saw the bottle breaking against the pavement and milk spreading along the kerb.

By morning, she had slept in fragments so short they felt imagined.

Wednesday passed in rules, rooms and faces she did not yet know how to read. By evening, exhaustion had begun to settle into her limbs. She thought that might help. She thought eventually the body would take what it needed whether the mind agreed or not.

That was when the interruptions began.

The light remained on above the bed.

When Zoe started to drift, the door opened.

Sometimes a woman came in to ask whether she wanted water. Sometimes a man told her to sit up while he checked the window latch, though nobody had touched it. Once they moved her to another room for less than an hour, then returned her to the first without explanation.

Each time, whatever edge of sleep she had reached disappeared.

The questions were ordinary enough to sound harmless.

What school did she attend?

What did Helen cook most often?

Did Brian drive to work?

Did Zoe have relatives nearby?

Had anyone ever taken her abroad?

They repeated questions she had already answered, changing one word at a time.

When Zoe pointed that out, the woman smiled.

“People remember differently when they’re tired.”

Zoe stopped answering unless she had to.

A television played somewhere downstairs, always loud enough to reach her and never clear enough to understand. Part of her mind kept reaching for sentences that never finished.

By Thursday morning, time had begun to come loose.

Meals arrived, but she could not always tell whether they belonged to breakfast or lunch. She remembered the colour of the plate more clearly than what had been on it. She counted the woman’s footsteps from the door to the bed three separate times and got three different answers.

She did not understand the design then.

She only knew that every interruption made the next question harder to hold onto. After enough hours, even anger required concentration.

So she began choosing what to keep.

The sound of the back door.

The number of stairs.

Which floorboard outside the room clicked beneath adult weight.

The smell of cigarette smoke that appeared before the tall lieutenant did.

Facts were easier than time.

She could lose an hour and still remember a lock.

"What were they trying to get you to agree to?" Elias asked.

"I didn't know yet," Zoe said. "Not exactly."

She adjusted the backpack against her knees.

"I knew something was coming. You could tell by the way the house changed."

"How?"

"People moved faster. Doors that were normally closed stayed open. Clothes appeared on beds. The woman with the rules kept checking the same list."

Elias said nothing.

"One of the men tested the lock on the study twice," Zoe continued. "Nobody had tried to open it. He checked anyway."

"A deadline."

"Yes."

"And they hadn't told you what it was."

"They didn't think I needed to know."

Thursday afternoon blurred at the edges, but certain details remained sharp.

Fresh clothes arrived in transparent bags.

The children were separated by age and moved between rooms. One woman inspected fingernails. Another checked hair, skin and teeth without explaining why.

Nobody called it preparation.

Nobody needed to.

Zoe held the older photograph in her memory: her own face at six or seven, laughing at something outside the frame. The file. The number. The word buyer spoken behind a door.

Each detail seemed separate because the adults had kept them

separate.

She began placing them together.

Not into an answer.

Into a shape.

That evening, the tall lieutenant entered the room.

The smell of cigarette smoke reached Zoe before he did.

He stood in the doorway without speaking, watching the children as though he were checking condition rather than seeing people. His gaze travelled from face to face, pausing longest on the ones who shifted or looked down.

When his eyes reached Zoe, they remained there.

She recognised him now as the man she would later see at the service station— the one whose face had emptied when he recognised Elias.

At the time, he was simply the person everyone else adjusted around.

Zoe did not look away first.

It was not courage.

Exhaustion had stripped away the smaller fears. Only the thing they were preparing her for remained.

The lieutenant left without speaking.

The room exhaled after him.

On Thursday night—the third night without proper sleep—Zoe heard two women talking in the corridor.

Their voices were low and businesslike. They discussed the following morning as though it were a scheduling problem.

“Tomorrow, then.”

“Depends if she’s settled by morning. He doesn’t like them jumpy.”

“She’ll be fine. They always are by the time we’re done.”

Zoe lay beneath the unbroken light and kept her breathing even.

She refused to guess what tomorrow meant.

Every possibility her mind produced was worse than the one before it.

Later, when the corridor had gone quiet again, one of the older girls was brought into the room.

Zoe recognised her as one of the children who had whispered Cain's name near the wall.

The girl sat on the floor beside Zoe's bed as though she had been told to wait there. She kept her eyes on the opposite wall.

After several minutes, she leaned just close enough to speak without turning her head.

"Tomorrow's the showing."

Zoe waited.

"Don't eat anything they give you before it," the girl whispered. "Don't drink anything either, if you can help it."

"Why?"

The girl's fingers tightened around the hem of her sleeve.

"Trust me."

"Have they done it to you?"

The girl's face changed by less than a movement.

That was enough.

A door opened somewhere along the corridor.

The girl stood immediately and moved away before anyone entered.

Zoe held the warning in her mind for the rest of the night, testing it against everything she had seen.

They had offered water she had not requested.

They monitored what the children ate.

They wanted them quiet.

They wanted them settled.

They always were by the time the adults were done.

The showing.

Zoe began to understand what she was to them.

Not a person being kept.

A thing being prepared.

Cleaned.

Quieted.

Made presentable for someone waiting on the other side of a word she still did not fully understand.

They had taken almost every decision from her.

Where she slept.

When she stood.

What she wore.

Which room she entered.

When she answered.

The older girl's warning gave one decision back.

It was small.

That did not make it unimportant.

Zoe decided she would not eat.

She would not drink.

And whatever happened in the morning, she would make them believe she had.

Elias drew a slow breath through his nose and held it before speaking.

"You don't have to finish this part now."

"I want to."

"You don't owe me the rest because you started."

"I know."

The answer came quickly enough that he believed her.

Zoe looked down at her hands.

"I've been carrying it alone," she said. "It's heavier than the talking is."

Elias looked at her in the mirror and did not ask again whether she was sure.

"All right," he said. "Whenever you're ready."

Zoe nodded and, after a breath of her own, continued.